SIDENT

LD BE SOMEONE ELSE ENTIRELY

THE DARK HORSES

Shivraj Singh Chouhan, *66*

Union Minister of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare



His governance record as MP CM and his mass connect remain his trump cards. Also seen as a man who can rally disparate factions



Sanjay Joshi, *63*

Politician

A Nagpur boy, former general secretary (organisation), who retains his ties with the likes of Mohan Bhagwat, Manmohan Vaidya and Nitin Gadkari

Vaidya and Nitin Gadkari. At 63, he is in the acceptable age bracket as well, but his run-ins with Modi when he was Gujarat chief minister may be a downer.

There were some rumours of a woman contender to helm the party. But no serious woman leader has emerged as a consensus candidate, and the idea may die a quiet death.

PREDICT AT YOUR PERIL

Both organisations have a history of springing surprises and, often, the more intense the speculation, the greater the likelihood that the eventual choice will be someone outside the frame. The elevation of Nitin Gadkari as party president in 2009 is a prime example. Just 52 then, Gadkari was relatively unknown outside Maharashtra, having served as state BJP president and minister in the Shiv Sena-BJP government. He had almost no experience in national politics. Yet, the Sangh—disenchanted with the infighting and stagnation of the Delhi old guard—pressed for his appointment to inject youthful energy into the party and bring ideological alignment. Gadkari's appointment blindsided the Delhi leadership, upended power equations and marked a shift in balance in the BJP organisation.

The RSS-BJP are also not always bound by public logic or apparent credentials. They prefer consensus, not contest. And that can take weeks, even months, of deliberations and behind-the-scenes persuasion. They have also been busy, first as the party pushed their muscle for the Delhi polls, then to build the political outreach to complement Operation Sindoor and now to identify a candidate for the vice-presidential election.

THE NEXT PARTY CHIEF WILL HAVE TO COMMAND SANGH'S TRUST, MODI'S CONFIDENCE AND THE CADRE'S RESPECT

As of August 2025, the party has achieved the quorum necessary to elect a new national president. According to the BJP constitution, the party must complete its internal elections in at least 50 per cent of the states and Union Territories. That threshold has been crossed, with 18-plus state units having completed the exercise, though critical states such as Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Karnataka, Jharkhand, Gujarat and Delhi have yet to deliver. Punjab had by the first week of August named only its first six district presidents, making it last in the queue, barring strife-torn Manipur.

In UP—a state crucial for both the party as well as the Sangh's ideological balance—four key changes are pending: a new state president, a replacement for Governor Anandiben Patel, a cabinet reshuffle and new national council nominees. The state delivered only 37 out of 80 seats in the 2024 parliamentary polls, prompting serious introspection. Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath remains popular and a key ideological figure, but the BJP's caste arithmetic and candidate strategy need urgent recalibration ahead of the 2027 assembly election. Similar exercises are underway in Haryana, Delhi, Jharkhand, Gujarat and Karnataka.

THE POST-MODI TEST

The RSS is well aware that Narendra Modi's mass appeal helped the Parivar reach newer demographics—urban aspirational classes, youth, women and marginalised castes. His popularity gave cover for ideological boldness and delivery on crucial agenda, be it the building of the Ram temple in Ayodhya or the abrogation of Article 370 in Jammu and Kashmir. But it also fostered top-down decision making, weakening internal debate. Now, with both Modi and RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat approaching the retirement threshold of 75, a new chapter is about to begin. No one in the BJP-Sangh expects the PM to hang up his boots anytime soon and it is agreed that he is needed to maintain their ideological and political trajectory. The next party chief will be the bridge. He will have to command the Sangh's trust, Modi's confidence, and the cadre's respect. His mandate will be as much to win elections—Opposition-ruled West Bengal, Tamil Nadu and Kerala go to polls in 2026—as to restore ideological depth, forge new caste coalitions, prevent factionalism and manage transitions both within and outside Modi's shadow.

As one party insider quipped recently: "We're not just choosing a party president, we're deciding who holds the map in a post-Modi landscape." The Sangh may hold the ideological compass. But the journey ahead will depend on whom it hands that compass to. ■